

Swipe. Scam. Repeat.

The financial technology (fintech) revolution has transformed how we invest, transact, and manage money. With just a few taps on a smartphone, users can transfer funds, trade cryptocurrency, apply for loans, and even automate savings. According to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), UPI transactions alone surpassed ₹17.4 lakh crore in December 2023, demonstrating the scale of digital finance adoption. However, with this rapid evolution comes a dark side: fintech fraud. Scammers exploit new technologies, regulatory loopholes, and user ignorance to steal billions from unsuspecting victims worldwide.

The numbers tell a grim story. The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) reported over ₹1.25 lakh crore lost to digital financial fraud in 2023, with phishing, UPI fraud, and fake investment schemes leading the charge. CERT-In, India's cybersecurity watchdog, has issued multiple alerts about increasing attacks on fintech users. Even global cybersecurity firms like Kaspersky and McAfee confirm that India is among the top five most targeted nations for fintech scams. The rise in deepfake technology, AI-powered phishing, and sophisticated impersonation scams makes it harder than ever to distinguish real from fake.

Fraudsters don't just rely on age-old tricks; they adapt to evolving fintech trends. They create

fake investment platforms, impersonate customer support agents, launch phishing websites that mimic trusted banks, and use social engineering to manipulate victims. A common tactic is leveraging social media ads and WhatsApp groups to promote fraudulent schemes, often backed by fabricated celebrity endorsements. The infamous GainBitcoin Ponzi scheme, which defrauded investors of over ₹20,000 crore, exemplifies how digital scams operate on a massive scale before authorities step in.

From seasoned investors to first-time digital payment users, no one is immune. Young professionals, lured by quick returns, fall victim to crypto rug-pulls, while senior citizens are often targeted through impersonation scams claiming "suspicious activity" on their accounts. Businesses also face risks, with scammers exploiting loopholes in payment gateways to siphon funds.

This booklet is your essential guide to recognising and avoiding fintech scams. Each chapter breaks down real-world fraud cases, the red flags to watch for, and practical steps to safeguard your financial assets. Whether you're an investor, a digital payments user, or simply someone who wants to stay secure, the insights here could save you from falling prey to the next big scam.

Financial fraud isn't just a personal loss—it's a systemic threat. Stay informed, stay alert, and most importantly, stay safe. **d**